

Illinois Institute of Technology

Biology Department Meeting Minutes

Date: October 1, 2025

Location: Room 129

Recorder: Natasha Washington

Proofreader: Lei Li

Attendees

Drs. Spink, Bekyarova, Lin, Xiang, Howard, Juarez, Smith, Ma, Corush, Li.

Quorum established.

Absentees

Dr. Tuz

Agenda Items

1. Approval of Agenda

- Motion made to prioritize assessment report approval due to October 15th deadline.
- Motion carried.

2. Program Assessment Reports

- BS Biology Program

Learning Objective (LO): Demonstration of technical skills in laboratory work: collecting, analyzing, and interpreting quantitative data.

Courses Assessed: Microbiology, Biochemistry Lab (CHEM 404), and Cell Lab.

Results:

- Aggregate: 82% of students met or exceeded expectations.
- Microbiology: Assessment via practical exam – mostly met expectations.
- Biochemistry Lab: Focused on equipment use – mixed results.
- Cell Lab: Students stronger in analyzing/interpreting data than technical skills.

Challenges:

- Disparate data sets across courses.
- Need consistent methodology and alignment with curriculum map.

Continuous Improvement Plan:

- Need to separate 'technical skills' from 'data analysis' in LO wording.
- Curriculum Committee with lab instructors to lead revisions.

Decision: Report to be revised with methodology notes and circulated via email for tentative approval.

- MS Biology Program

LO: Demonstrate effective oral and written communication.

Assessment:

- Oral skills: Final Capstone presentations (peer + instructor feedback).
 - Results: Majority proficient; 27% at expectations.
- Written skills: Final lab report in BIO 533.
 - Results: Written skills weaker than oral.

Continuous Improvement Plan:

- Continue peer feedback model.
- Strengthen scientific writing support in coursework.

- PhD Biology Program

Assessment Method: Annual meeting with graduate committee + faculty (student presentations, faculty rubric).

- 7 students assessed in 2025 cycle.

LO Assessed: Critical thinking (independent/logical thinking, data interpretation, troubleshooting, experiment design).

Results:

- 6 of 7 students met or exceeded expectations.
- One first-year student scored below expectations.

Challenges:

- Professionalism LO difficult to assess objectively.
- Options discussed: CITI training, faculty committee input, publication/conference presentations.

Future Plan:

- Collect longitudinal data (4–5 years).
- Revise assessment plan for long-term reporting.

Decision: Tentatively approved; professionalism LO assessment methods to be refined.

- MS Health Profession

Low-Enrollment Programs. Programs with very small enrollments will submit cumulative assessment reports every four years.

3. 3. Meeting Schedule

- October assessment deadline noted.
- November meeting conflicts with university faculty meeting. Natasha to circulate poll for new date.
- Interim October meeting suggested. Denied by the dept chair.

Decisions & Action Items

- BS Biology Report: Katie to revise and circulate.
- MS Biology Report: Accepted with recommendations.
- PhD Biology Report: Tentatively approved with professionalism LO refinement.
- Curriculum Committee: To consult with lab instructors on technical skills assessment.
- Natasha to circulate November meeting poll.

Meeting Summary – Biology Department (September 22, 2025)

The Biology Department focused primarily on program assessment reports ahead of the October 15 deadline:

- BS Program: Students proficient in data analysis but weaker in lab technical skills. Department will refine LO wording and assessment methods.
- MS Program: Strong oral communication outcomes; written communication improvement needed.
- PhD Program: Strong performance in critical thinking. Professionalism LO assessment under development. Future plans include CITI training, faculty input, and potential publication/conference measures.
- Low-Enrollment Programs: Will report on a four-year cumulative cycle.

Next Steps: Reports revised and circulated by email; curriculum committee to review technical skills assessment; Natasha to poll faculty for November meeting date.